

Columbus Roads: Top 20 to Avoid + Top 20 to Use

A free field guide for drivers in and around Columbus, Ohio. Twenty corridors that often cost you time or stress — and twenty better options when the goal is a calmer trip.

How this list was built

This is a **curated practical list**, not an official ranking. Each pick was weighed using five inputs:

1. **Road quality** — pavement condition, lane drops, awkward merges, and “feels worn down” stretches drivers talk about often
2. **Maintenance / construction** — recurring work zones and multi-year rebuilds (especially Innerbelt / Crossroads phases)
3. **Accident patterns** — publicly discussed high-crash corridors and intersections (MORPC / ODPS / ODOT reporting over time)
4. **Travel time** — peak-hour delay, weekend retail crush, and event-day backups
5. **User input** — common local advice (what friends, coworkers, and long-time drivers actually avoid or recommend)

Important: Crash lists and construction change. Check [ODOT OHGO](#), city alerts, and your maps app the morning of. Send corrections or “this got better / worse” notes to businesshouseholder@gmail.com — future editions will fold that feedback in.

Quick rules before you drive

- ☐ Peek at OHGO / maps for crashes and lane closures
 - ☐ Add 15–25 minutes for Innerbelt, Morse, Polaris, and campus-event windows
 - ☐ Prefer one calm arterial over three “shortcut” cuts through neighborhoods
 - ☐ If you’re unfamiliar with downtown one-ways, stay on the freeway outer belt until you’re closer
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Top 20 roads to avoid (when you can)

1. I-70 / I-71 downtown overlap (Innerbelt / Crossroads)

Why: Chronic congestion + high crash share for its length; multi-year rebuild phases.

Worst times: Weekday peaks, Friday afternoons, bad weather, any crash.

Try instead: I-270 around for through trips; I-670 when it still moves.

2. I-71 East Trench / downtown east rebuild zones

Why: Active construction, lane shifts, and surprise merges.

Worst times: Weekday mornings into downtown; overnight work bursts.

Try instead: Surface one-ways (Long / Spring / Broad) for short hops once you’re already downtown.

3. SR-315 through the downtown / north crush

Why: Volume + limited escape lanes; backups stack fast after one incident.

Worst times: Weekday peaks; event nights.

Try instead: Riverside Drive (slower, calmer) or Kenny / Olentangy River Road segments when they fit your start/end.

4. Morse Road (retail spine, especially Karl → Cleveland)

Why: Dense driveways, turning conflicts, and historically busy crash intersections.

Worst times: Lunch, after-work, Saturday midday.

Try instead: Parallel east-west options north/south of Morse for through trips (Agler / Innis / Schrock depending on end point).

5. Cleveland Avenue (key crash intersections)

Why: Long arterial with repeated high-crash junctions in regional lists over the years.

Worst times: Peaks and dark/wet evenings.

Try instead: I-71 for longer north-south moves; local collectors for short neighborhood hops.

6. East Broad Street (high-injury network stretches)

Why: On the city's Vision Zero high-injury focus; busy, wide, and historically risky.

Worst times: Peaks; late-night speeding windows.

Note: Safety demo projects have been changing the street — still drive extra careful.

Try instead: Main / Town / Livingston for some east-side trips; I-70 for longer east-west.

7. East Livingston Avenue (esp. near Brice / Hamilton)

Why: High-volume intersections that repeatedly show up in regional crash discussions.

Worst times: After-work eastbound, weekends.

Try instead: Main Street / Refugee connectors or I-70 when heading farther out.

8. SR-161 / Dublin-Granville Road (retail & ramp chaos)

Why: Shopping access + freeway ramps = stop-and-go and side-swipe risk.

Worst times: Evenings and weekends near big retail.

Try instead: I-270 for distance; Wilson Bridge / Worthington locals for short trips.

9. Hilliard Rome Road (Renner / retail cluster)

Why: Turn conflicts and peak backups at major junctions.

Worst times: Weekday evenings, Saturday midday.

Try instead: I-70 for longer moves; Trabue / Fishinger for west-side crosstown.

10. Frank Road / Refugee / Winchester Pike area

Why: Complex junctions and freight + local mix.

Worst times: Peaks and truck-heavy midday.

Try instead: Alum Creek Drive / Gender Road for many SE patterns.

11. Sawmill Road (Dublin-Worthington retail corridor)

Why: Constant driveway friction and light-to-light delay.

Worst times: Lunch and after-work.

Try instead: Hard Road / Emerald Parkway / Avery-Cosgray for many NW trips.

12. Polaris Parkway (weekend retail crush)

Why: Destination traffic overwhelms the corridor.

Worst times: Saturday midday-afternoon; holiday weeks.

Try instead: I-71 to outer Polaris access points; arrive earlier or park once.

13. High Street (campus / Short North event windows)

Why: Pedestrian density, event surges, and stop-start blocks.

Worst times: Game days, festival nights, weekend evenings.

Try instead: Parallel north-south streets a few blocks over; rideshare for the last mile.

14. I-270 NW arc (Dublin–Worthington) at peaks

Why: Through traffic + local on/off ramps; one crash freezes the belt.

Worst times: Weekday AM/PM.

Try instead: Hard / Emerald / Sawmill only if your trip is short and local.

15. I-670 downtown merges

Why: Short weaves and sudden slowdowns.

Worst times: Peaks and airport rushes.

Try instead: Stay on I-270 longer for airport trips when maps show 670 jammed.

16. Bethel Road (retail stretch)

Why: Driveways + peaks = slow and fender-bender friendly.

Worst times: Lunch and after-work.

Try instead: Henderson / Godown / local collectors for neighborhood trips.

17. Olentangy River Road (north / campus-adjacent peaks)

Why: Commuter volume and limited passing room in places.

Worst times: Weekday peaks.

Try instead: Kenny Road or SR-315 only when it's actually moving; bike/transit for short campus hops.

18. Hamilton Road (south of Easton, peak windows)

Why: Retail + apartment density; left turns stack up.

Worst times: Evenings and Saturdays.

Try instead: I-270 for longer runs; parallel collectors for local errands.

19. Tuttle Crossing / mall access roads

Why: Destination spikes and short merges.

Worst times: Weekend afternoons and holidays.

Try instead: Enter from the less obvious side roads; shop off-peak.

20. Lane Avenue / campus-edge connectors (event days)

Why: Event surge + limited outlets.

Worst times: Stadium / arena arrival and exit waves.

Try instead: Park farther out and walk/rideshare; leave 30+ minutes early.

Top 20 roads to use (smarter defaults)

1. I-270 (outer belt) for through trips

Why: Usually beats fighting downtown when you're not stopping downtown.

Best for: Airport ↔ suburbs, north ↔ south without Innerbelt pain.

2. I-670 (when it's clear)

Why: Fast downtown-airport and east-side connector — until it isn't.

Best for: Airport runs outside peak crash chaos.

3. Riverside Drive

Why: Calmer parallel to SR-315 for many north-south local trips.

Best for: Scenic, lower-stress driving when time isn't critical.

4. Kenny Road

Why: Useful north-side parallel when Olentangy / 315 are stacked.

Best for: Worthington / north Columbus local travel.

5. Hard Road + Emerald Parkway

Why: Planned suburban arterials that often beat Sawmill stop-and-go.

Best for: Dublin / NW errands and office parks.

6. Avery Road / Cosgray Road

Why: Western Dublin connectors with fewer driveway fights than Sawmill.

Best for: NW ↔ west local trips.

7. Trabue Road / Fishinger Road

Why: Solid west-side east-west movement without Hilliard Rome retail crush.

Best for: Hilliard / UA / west Columbus.

8. Alum Creek Drive

Why: Predictable SE spine for freight and locals.

Best for: Rickenbacker / SE industrial and south-east suburbs.

9. Gender Road

Why: Canal Winchester / SE connector that often beats Livingston chaos.

Best for: SE suburbs ↔ I-70 area.

10. McNaughten Road / Noe-Bixby Road

Why: East-side alternatives when Livingston is ugly.

Best for: Reynoldsburg / east Columbus local runs.

11. Schrock Road

Why: Westerville / NE belt alternative to Morse for many trips.

Best for: NE crosstown without the Morse retail gauntlet.

12. Agler Road / Innis Road (as Morse bypass pieces)

Why: Not glamorous — but often move when Morse doesn't.

Best for: East-west hops north/south of Morse.

13. Wilson Bridge Road

Why: Worthington connector that avoids some SR-161 retail mess.
Best for: Worthington locals and I-270 access.

14. Spring Street / Long Street (downtown one-ways)

Why: Designed for downtown flow once you know the grid.
Best for: Short downtown hops — learn them before peak hour.

15. Goodale Street / Nationwide Blvd area

Why: Useful Arena District / downtown north edge movement.
Best for: Short downtown / near-north trips.

16. Third Street / Front Street (downtown N-S when clear)

Why: Often cleaner than High Street during events.
Best for: Downtown north-south without the High Street crowd.

17. Broad Street west of downtown (for short local trips)

Why: Can beat a freeway hop for short distances — watch Vision Zero zones east.
Best for: Near-west / Hilltop local.

18. Main Street (select east-side segments)

Why: Parallel option when Broad / Livingston are jammed.
Best for: Near East / Bexley-adjacent patterns (watch local speed limits).

19. Easton outer loop roads (not the core crush)

Why: Edge access beats fighting the center lots and Morse feeders.
Best for: Easton trips — park once, walk the rest.

20. Neighborhood collectors + timed lights (your “local knowledge” roads)

Why: The best road is often the one two blocks off the arterial.
Best for: Repeat trips you’ve tested at your real departure time.

Swap cheat sheet

If you’re stuck on...	First try...
Innerbelt I-70/71	I-270 around, or I-670 if clear
SR-315	Riverside Dr / Kenny Rd
Morse Rd	Schrock / Agler / Innis
Sawmill Rd	Hard / Emerald / Avery-Cosgray
Livingston Ave	Main / McNaughten / Noe-Bixby / I-70
Hilliard Rome Rd	Trabue / Fishinger / I-70

High Street event crush	Parallel streets + last-mile rideshare
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Trip planner (fill in)

Usual commute / frequent trip: _____

Roads I currently use: _____

Roads I will try instead: _____

Time saved / stress change after one week: _____

Send user input (this guide improves with your notes)

Email businesshouseholder@gmail.com with:

- Road name + stretch (from / to)
- Time of day
- What happened (crash, pavement, construction, delay)
- What you used instead and whether it helped

Subject line idea: `Columbus roads feedback`

Sources to re-check yourself

- [OHGO traffic & construction](#)
 - [MORPC transportation safety](#)
 - [City of Columbus street & road projects](#)
 - [Vision Zero Columbus](#) (search "Vision Zero")
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Buckeye Trail Guide · Curated by Keith Householder · Columbus, Ohio

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Road conditions, crash patterns, and construction change — verify before you drive. This is practical guidance, not an official safety ranking.